

Backup software

Hardware is nothing without the software that empowers it. This holds true for backup solutions as well. You need software that will automatically back up your data, with the least amount of human intervention required. The software should also have extra features such as saving a specific folder only, compressing the backups, timed intervals for backups, etc. Consider some of the following alternatives

1. **Secondcopy2000** (www.centered.com) Rs 1,380
2. **Dantz Retrospect Professional** (www.dantz.com) Rs 5,940
3. **Securdat Pro 2.1** (www.pa-soft.com) Rs 1,100

sionals who have large amounts of data for frequent backups.

Though re-writable media are available, CD-Rs are still preferred, and this means a new CD for each backup. Also, CDs are subject to corruption via scratches and exposure to the elements. Your precious data can soon become nothing more than a coffee mug coaster. The price-per-MB for CDs is the lowest—two or three paise per MB. This media is recommended for situations where backups are not accessed frequently—in fact only where backups are accessed rarely.

Miscellaneous storage

Iomega recently launched Rev Drive—a hard drive intelligently divided into two parts. This drive stores 35 GB in uncompressed form, and 90 GB in compressed form. It's a



Iomega Rev Drive

good solution to backing up a hard drive on its last legs. Rev is available in the ATAPI and USB 2.0 interface, and is quite simple to use.

The problem with such proprietary drives is that users are stuck with one format, as was the case earlier with ZIP and JAZ drives. You can't access your backup on

anything but a Rev drive, which is an Iomega standard.

USB sticks are another option that can be used for temporary storage of data. They are portable and convenient, but the problem is they are expensive—a 128 MB USB stick cost between Rs 2,500 to Rs 3,000. The price-per-MB ratio is pathetically high, thus making it only good for transference of data, and not backing up.

The last word

Your data will never be totally safe, but you can use one, or a combination of two or more of the afore mentioned options to minimise the risk of data loss. In business, the lower the risk factors, the better you will sleep at night. Look towards securing your company records, and as a result your business, by using an intelligent hybrid of hard drive and optical backup solutions. ■

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What I would buy

Even backup hard drives are components in the end, and can fail. So should you have a backup for your backup drive? Yes—if your data is important enough, or if you are paranoid enough. We suggest two hard drives configured to Mirroring in RAID (Redundant Array of Inexpensive Disks). This ensures that one drive is used as backup, and an exact copy is made on the second disk. You can also convert an internal hard drive into an external hard drive by buying a convertor kit. This kit costs about Rs 2,000. We recommend a Western Digital WD2500 250 GB hard drive, which costs Rs 17,500.

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